

Documentation Examples: Subjective vs. Objective Language

Use these examples to guide professional documentation practices.

Objective documentation describes what you observe — what the child does and says, when, where, how often, and for how long. It does not include labels, diagnoses, interpretations, or judgments.

Example 1: Social-Emotional Development

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>Mia is very emotional and dramatic. She can't handle it when she doesn't get her way.</i>	During free play on three separate mornings this week, Mia cried for 8–12 minutes when another child took a toy she was using. She said 'That's mine!' and lay on the floor. She did not respond to verbal redirection during the first 5 minutes of each episode.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 2: Physical or Mobility

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>He has motor problems and can't do anything the other kids do.</i>	During outdoor time, Devon was unable to climb the ladder to the slide independently. He reached the third rung and stopped on 4 out of 5 attempts. He completed the slide with adult hand support. He did not participate in the running game.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 3: Attention and Learning

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